



Design Thinking for

STRATEGIC CAPACITY PLANNING

The Ask: To elevate capacity planning by introducing design thinking; empowering teams, cultivating a strategic mindset & fostering proactive planning

The Result: A shared Design Thinking mindset and a strong foundation to lead capacity planning with intent, empathy, and strategic clarity.

WORKSHOPS AT A GLANCE

9

Online workshops

5

Resource
management
teams involved

14+

Core challenge
themes identified
across teams

100+

Cups of coffee



“Design thinking is a human-centered approach to innovation that draws from the designer’s toolkit to integrate the needs of people, the possibilities of technology, and the requirements for business success.”

— Tim Brown, Executive Chair of IDEO

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THE OBJECTIVE

To build **awareness and consideration** for design thinking; cultivating a **strategic mindset that fosters proactive capacity planning**

THE APPROACH

Enabling an understanding of the **‘Why, What and How’** of Design Thinking

Developing shared clarity on the application of **Design Thinking in the context of Capacity Planning**

Hands-on experience of **problem framing and problem solving through Design Thinking** principles and frameworks

THE OUTCOME



Embedded Design Thinking within teams with the “Why-before-how” mindset



Re-imagined current challenges through the design thinking lens



A hands—on experience of collaborative problem solving using the Design Thinking approach

THE TEAM

Capacity Planning Team



**Adam (AO)
Organ**



**Dave
Raffaele**



**Derek
Cheever**



**Karima
Sundarji**



**Lindsay
Hayes**



**Scott
Miles**



**Shannon
Williams**



**Traci
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DGS Experience Strategy Team



**Pradnya
Salvekar**



**Rishab
Raina**



**Saadeen
Anwar**



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Banerjee**



**Shubham
Kelaskar**



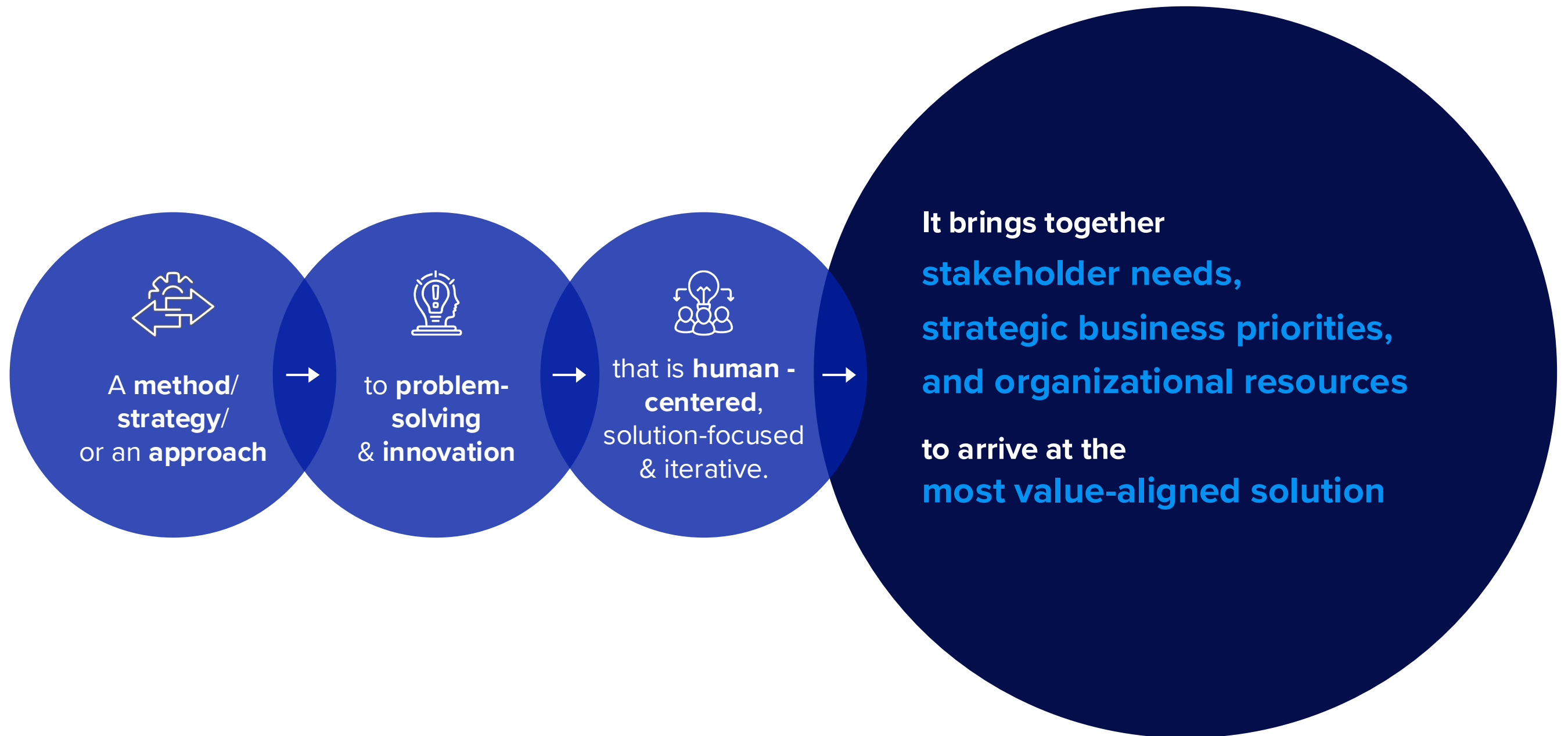
**Snehal
Sanghavi**

UNDERSTANDING DESIGN THINKING

What would happen if everyone started to think like designers?

When traditional approaches are ineffective, it can be helpful to tap into the creative side to collaborate and solve problems in human-centered ways.

WHAT IS DESIGN THINKING?



ELEVATING CAPACITY PLANNING WITH DESIGN THINKING

How Design Thinking can help enhance processes, collaboration and decision-making with a more strategic purview

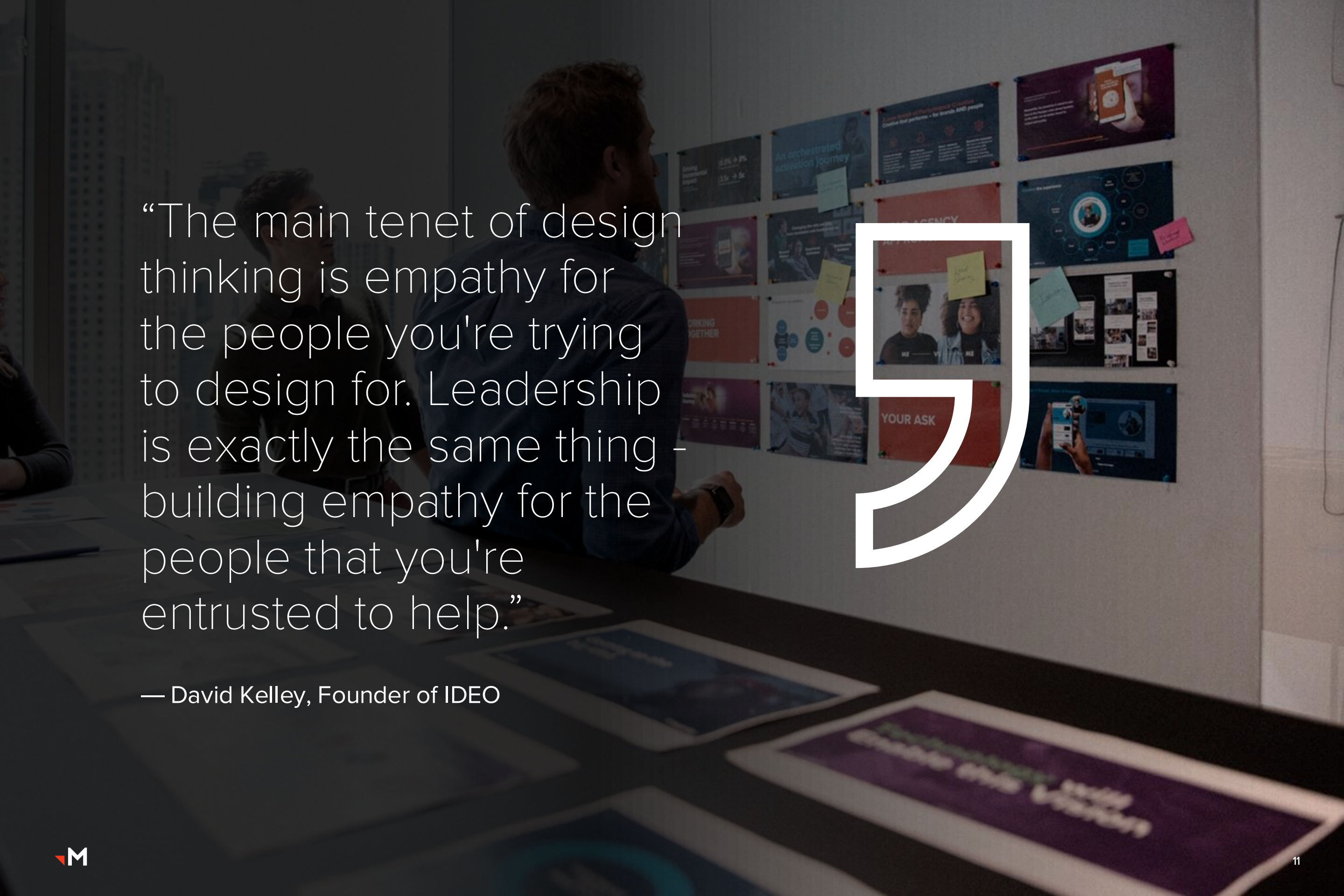
Enables capacity planning to be more proactive and future looking

Aligns capacity decisions with business strategy

Accelerates learning and adaptation

Improves decision quality under uncertainty

Breaks functional silos



“The main tenet of design thinking is empathy for the people you're trying to design for. Leadership is exactly the same thing – building empathy for the people that you're entrusted to help.”

— David Kelley, Founder of IDEO

SUCCESS UNLOCKED THROUGH DESIGN THINKING IN TECHNOLOGY SERVICES

Problem

- | Software **migration processes** were **manual and inefficient**, leading to project delays

What we Did

- | Defined key stakeholders and their needs
- | Presented future tech trends to guide creative & disruptive thinking
- | Conducted a process walkthrough and analysis to identify task effort, time taken & pain points

Outcome

- | A **shared vision** and supporting themes for optimizing their processes
- | An **action plan consisting of 5 bold steps** to achieve the vision



SUCCESS UNLOCKED THROUGH DESIGN THINKING IN HEALTHCARE

Problem

- | **Low adoption and engagement** amongst patients with the brands' digital assets

What we Did

- | Conducted an ideation workshop with stakeholders
- | Secondary research on existing pharmaceutical platforms
- | Identified and defined the 3 personas: HCP, sales rep, and patient
- | Generated ideas for features to enhance engagement and collaboration for these personas

Outcome

- | Aligned stakeholder **vision**
- | Arrived at over **20 actionable ideas** to improve the engagement and experience of their pharmaceutical platform

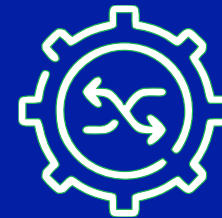


HOW DESIGN THINKING CAN BE APPLIED



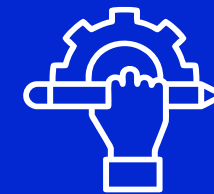
ADOPT the Design
Thinking
MINDSET

Laying the foundation by
understanding underlying problems



APPLY Design
Thinking principles
in **PROCESS**

Attaining clarity by providing
structure and discipline to creativity



MAKE Design
Thinking a daily
PRACTICE

Thinking translated to action
with iteration, experimentation
and reflection

ENABLING A TACTICAL TO STRATEGIC SHIFT WITH DESIGN THINKING

Apply Design Thinking Principles	to shift from Tactical Focus	to Strategic Capabilities
Empathy	Surface-level user needs	Deep understanding of root causes and latent needs
Iteration	One-time solutions and fixes	Continuous improvement and long-term sustainability
Collaboration	Siloed departmental approaches	Systems thinking and integrated problem-solving
Problem Definition	Accepting surface problems as given	Challenging assumptions and finding root problems
Creativity	Incremental improvements	Breakthrough innovation and new business models

MAPPING CURRENT STATE

The teams' processes and stakeholders were mapped to get a deeper understanding of their decision-making, and on-ground realities; ensuring that the right problems could be surfaced for solutioning

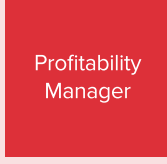
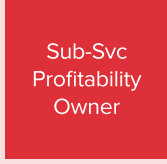
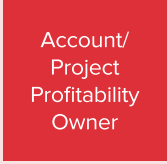
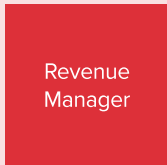
IDENTIFYING EXTERNAL STAKEHOLDERS

This gave a clear view of interdependencies and direct or indirect influences on resource management processes.

Problem identified

Lack of standard/consistent definitions and key responsibilities for same roles like Account management, Client Partners, PMOs, etc. across different practices

Stakeholders with indirect impact



Stakeholders with direct impact



DEFINING INTERNAL STAKEHOLDERS

This brought a deeper understanding of the ecosystem – how internal cohorts differ from and interact with each other.



PROCESS FLOWS ACROSS VERTICALS

CARDINAL PATH

1

Demand & Pipeline Planning

What Happens

Sales/Growth teams record new, renewal, and expanded project bookings in the RM system.

Once a project is sold, RM converts pipeline bookings into confirmed client bookings.

RM reviews pipeline, current demand, and forecasts daily and aligns with stakeholders through weekly, monthly, and quarterly discussions.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Growth Team
Practice/CP PM (Project Manager)
Sales Team

Emotion



Neutral

Key Challenges

- Delayed demand awareness or incomplete information to plan for staffing
- Misalignment between capacity and demand
- Poor "Source Of Truth" Culture

2

Forecast Planning

What Happens

The pipeline and known upcoming demand is the basis for labor forecasting which is used to anticipate hiring and internal resourcing needs.

The forecast highlights long or short lead times.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Sales Team
Practice/CP

Emotion



Uncertain

Key Challenges

- Difficulties in forecast vs actuals reporting
- Lack of system and process integration (PSA)
- Forecasts cannot keep up with incoming demand
- Inconsistencies in financial inputs

3

Internal Resourcing & Assignment

What Happens

Based on pipeline booking, RM checks availability of resources and submits assignments for approval.

Once approved, RM shares resource assignment update with PMs, who update the pipeline bookings.

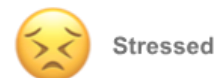
PMs raise ad hoc staffing requests for existing projects.

ICAs need to be created when resources are borrowed or lent across brands.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Practice/CP
DGS Teams (India/PH)
TA (Talent Acquisition)

Emotion



Stressed

Key Challenges

- Time-intensive, manual efforts
- Lack of system and process integration (PSA)

4

Hiring Resources

What Happens

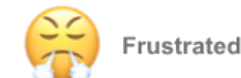
When a hiring need arises, RM assesses skill requirements, urgency, and timelines, creates a requisition

The requisition request is routed through leadership approvals to TA to initiate hiring.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager)
PM (Project Manager)

Emotion



Frustrated

Key Challenges

- Extended hiring timelines
- Misalignment between TA and RM on hiring expectations
- Lack of system and process integration (PSA)

5

Reporting and Revenue Goals

What Happens

RMs create chargeability and forecast reports using inputs from Workday, pipeline bookings and other RM systems.

RMs review chargeability, forecast vs. pipeline, and staffing gaps.

Reports are shared with leadership and finance to support planning and investment decisions.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) HR Ops Finance
Practice/CP

Emotion



Skeptical

Key Challenges

- Inconsistent opportunity management
- Limited cross-team interactions and unaligned workflows
- Low visibility and influence of CP on strategic business decisions

CRG/STRATEGY

1

Demand Planning

What Happens

RM hold weekly meeting for open roles review visible on the RM status report and Power BI.

RM also take notes and view actuals on the RM status report, and update assignments on WorkFront on a daily and/or weekly basis

Personas Involved

CRG/Strategy Sales Team

Emotion



Uncertain

Key Challenges

- Delayed demand awareness or incomplete information to plan for staffing
- Inconsistent Opportunity Management
- Incapability of tools to handle adjustments on opportunities

2

Supply Planning

What Happens

Discussions and reviews held over resourcing, allocations, availabilities, and people interested in moving accounts

Talks with sub-practice leads on resourcing over monthly meetings and with TA on hiring updates over bi-weekly or weekly meetings

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Sub-practice Leads
TA (Talent Acquisition)

Emotion



Frustrated

Key Challenges

- Low visibility and influence of CP on selling
- Lack of Internal & External Talent Market intel
- TA not aware of expectations and their role in partnership across hubs

3

Revenue Forecasting

What Happens

Revenue numbers are cross-checked across Salesforce, pricing tools and actuals for accuracy in reporting

Earliest hire date on WorkDay is manually updated to align with actuals

RM does monthly pipeline reviews with each sub-practice lead

Personas Involved

CRG/Strategy RM (Resource Manager)
TA (Talent Acquisition) Sub-practice Leads
Finance Ops Leaders

Emotion



Stressed

Key Challenges

- Inconsistencies in financial inputs
- Lack of standard engagement models
- Time-intensive, manual efforts
- Forecasting efforts can't keep up with incoming demand

4

Data Cleanup, Team Support & Special Projects

What Happens

As planning continues, teams spend time fixing data, pulling reports, and supporting ad-hoc asks.

They manually update multiple tools, pull reports from RM status reports / Excel, and share updates via emails and meetings.

Additional time is spent to follow up to validate data accuracy, slowing momentum.

Personas Involved

CRG/Strategy Ops TA (Talent Acquisition)
RM (Resource Manager)
Finance

Emotion



Exhausted

Key Challenges

- Hiring talent taking longer than anticipated
- No bench policy
- Resignation period is long

5

Business Goals Communication

What Happens

Finally, CRG / Strategy engages with Team to understand business direction and align planning.

They participate in recurring meetings, communicate insights and gaps, and try to stay aligned with evolving business needs.

Monthly meetings with senior leadership to discuss issues and strategies

Personas Involved

CRG/Strategy HR Client Partners
Sales Team Sub-practice Lead

Emotion



Skeptical

Key Challenges

- No clear organizational charter for RM

EXPERIENCE & COMMERCE

1 Demand & Pipeline Planning What Happens RM receives new opportunities in Salesforce when it reached the required sales stage. RM reviews pipeline and demand planning is done. RM aligns with Sales to resolve issues and with PTLs on high-priority opportunities. Personas Involved Sales TeamAccount ManagersSub PTL OpsOffshore & Nearshore RMsPractice/Sub-Practice Leads Emotion Neutral Key Challenges • Full demand not represented in tool • Inconsistent & Diffuse Delivery Management • Delayed demand awareness or incomplete information to plan for staffing	2 Supply Planning What Happens With demand visibility, available resources are matched based on skills and certifications. If hiring is needed, requisition is created and sent to stakeholders for approvals, after which TA initiates hiring. Contingent worker planning is also done based on demand. Personas Involved RM (Resource Manager)Sub PTLOffshore & Nearshore RMsSub PTL OpsPractice Leads Emotion Uneasy Key Challenges • Restricted mobility of talent across CXM and/or brands • Lack of understanding of profitability metrics incentivizing behaviors • Lack of internal and external talent market intel • Lack of time for proactive planning	3 Practice Revenue/Margin Goals What Happens RM reviews and validates utilization, timecards, invoices, and forecast numbers for an accurate picture on revenue. RM conducts periodic discussions with Finance, Practice Leads, and HR, to assess account-level margins and revenue leakage. Personas Involved Practice LeadsSub PTLFinance TeamDelivery Team Leads Emotion Concerned Key Challenges • Diffused and inconsistent pricing approach • Disconnected from practice goals • Revenue and margin data not clearly tied to staffing	4 Forecast Planning What Happens Forecast planning is done for staffing, utilization and revenue Departure planning and contingent worker planning is addressed Personas Involved RM (Resource Manager)Sub PTL OpsPractice LeadsFinance Team Emotion Stressed Key Challenges • Disconnected or outdated data sources for forecasting • Disconnected from sales decisions • Time-intensive, manual efforts	5 Data Cleanup, Team Support & Special Projects What Happens RM spends time updating and reconciling data across tools along with RM internal site updates RM also supports one-off special projects and supporting other teams with resources and RM enablement Personas Involved RM (Resource Manager)HRRM Internal OpsFinance TeamOther Ops Teams Emotion Overwhelmed Key Challenges • Lack of clear process, RACI, and Governance • Time-intensive, manual efforts	6 Business Goals Communication What Happens Tools and reports are shared with PTLs and leaders and deliveries and wins updates are shared in meetings RM reviews shoring mix and pyramid mix Time is also given to learning tools and building new processes Personas Involved CRG/StrategySub-practice LeadClient PartnersSales TeamHRTA (Talent Acquisition) Emotion Skeptical Key Challenges • Low visibility and influence of CP on strategic business decisions • No clear organizational charter for RM • Limited cross-team interactions and unaligned workflows
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CRM

1

Opportunity Management

What Happens

The pipeline is reviewed to check for new opportunities and an assessment is done of their type and the speed at which it is advancing across the sales stages. Depending on this planning for these opportunities is initiated.

In case of renewal of existing opportunity or a change in scope, it is validated by project owner, and there is again a review of the speed followed by a check on resource availability.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Practice Lead
Practice / Sub-practice Lead Finance
Sales/Account Lead CRM/Ops

Emotion



Neutral

Key Challenges

- Delayed demand awareness
- Pricing dependency for roles and hours
- Lack of internal and external talent marking intel
- Inconsistent and diffused delivery management

2

Priced Demand Review

What Happens

Once a demand is visible, RM conducts a priced demand review wherein a team is modelled for the opportunity and its cost is compared against the revenue.

After a team is named, RM checks availability of resources, validates any net new changes and creates a pricing tool which is reviewed and updated continuously depending on changes in opportunity.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Finance/Pricing
Finance Sales

Emotion



Concerned

Key Challenges

- Inconsistencies in financial inputs
- Diffused and inconsistent pricing approach

3

WorkFront Demand Review

What Happens

Demand from WorkFront is reviewed to determine if it can be fulfilled internally by available resources or if there's a need for hiring.

Assignments are confirmed when resources are available.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Practice Lead
HR TA (Talent Acquisition)

Emotion



Confused

Key Challenges

- Incapability of tools to handle adjustments on opportunities
- Full demand not represented in tool

4

Employee Status Change Review

What Happens

RM keeps a check on employee status - Last Working Day (LWD) and Leave of Absence (LoA) to assess if there's a gap and a role needs to be filled.

The role can be filled by reshuffling, promoting or hiring resources.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Workforce Ops
TA (Talent Acquisition) Practice Lead

Emotion



Stressed

Key Challenges

- Inconsistent and diffused delivery management
- Poor plan change communication protocol

5

Data Cleanup

What Happens

RM spend time throughout the journey in studying and cleaning data that they receive through multiple sources.

They also note and share status updates.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Sales Finance
Practice Lead TA (Talent Acquisition)

Emotion



Exhausted

Key Challenges

- Disconnected or outdated sources of data
- Poor "source of truth" culture
- Time intensive manual efforts

ANALYTICS & CDS

1

Opportunity Management

What Happens

Demand surfaces via pipeline calls, weekly open roles, and Ops syncs.

WF open demand is created, often reacting to near-term needs.

Alignment happens more through meetings than systems.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Practice Lead
Practice/Sub-practice Lead Finance
Sales/Account Lead CRM/Ops

Emotion



Key Challenges

- Opportunities sit open for long periods in SF without clarity
- Dependency on sales team/ project owner to update new opportunity on Workfront
- Updates rely on manual follow-ups impacting planning
- Limited integration across tools

2

Priced Demand Review

What Happens

Teams assess availability and redeploy resources based on scope changes or lost work

TA is looped in when internal movement is insufficient and is time consuming.

Decisions are influenced based on the resource availability during the weekly CDS calls.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Ops Lead
Business/Practice Lead

Emotion



Key Challenges

- RM doesn't have visibility on skills for internal resources.
- Some teams are unwilling to share resources across CXM as teams don't want to lose resource or revenue.
- Time being spent working with TA to fill roles.
- TA lack understanding of budget/ affordability when filling a role.

3

WorkFront Demand Review

What Happens

Capacity, utilization, and margin scenarios are built.

Numbers are cross-checked with Ops and Finance.

Pricing and cost assumptions are manually reconciled.

Personas Involved

Practice/Business Lead Finance Team
Ops Lead

Emotion



Key Challenges

- Inconsistent pricing and cost inputs
- Manual recalculations across versions
- Inaccuracies and duplication of data

4

Employee Status Change Review

What Happens

Forecasts and dashboards are shared in Ops / CDS reviews.

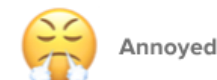
Pushbacks lead to revisions and rework.

Data is cleaned and revalidated before every review.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Ops Lead
CDS/Analytics Team

Emotion



Key Challenges

- Data not review-ready by default
- Delays due to multiple data sources
- WF updates lag behind actual decisions

5

Data Cleanup

What Happens

Demand is revised and executed via internal moves or hiring.

Progress is tracked informally until the next cycle.

Exceptions are handled outside standard workflows.

Personas Involved

RM (Resource Manager) Ops Lead HR
TA (Talent Acquisition)

Emotion



Key Challenges

- Struggles with hiring or internal resourcing
- TA lack understanding of budget/ affordability when filling a role.
- Inconsistent and exception-based processes
- Teams operating in Silos

DECODING INPUTS TO INSIGHTS

Team inputs were synthesized to discover patterns and filter challenges, enabling focused and aligned solutioning.

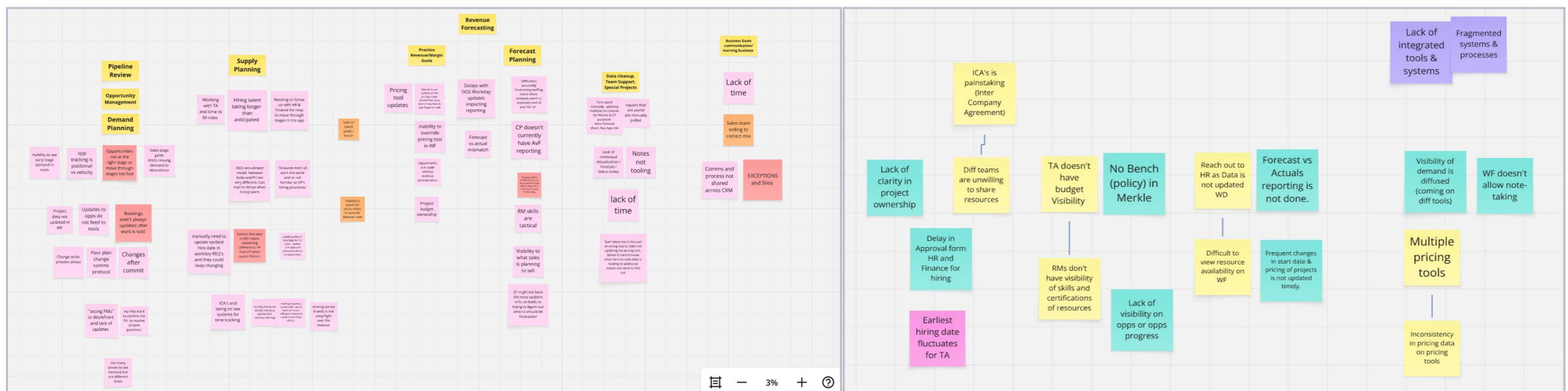
HOW WE SYNTHESIZED THE INPUTS

Synthesis turned multiple perspectives into a shared view, pushing focus from tactical issues to a strategic solutioning outlook

Analyzed inputs to discover patterns and commonalities from across teams

Narrowed down to strategic challenges by distinguishing them from tactical symptoms

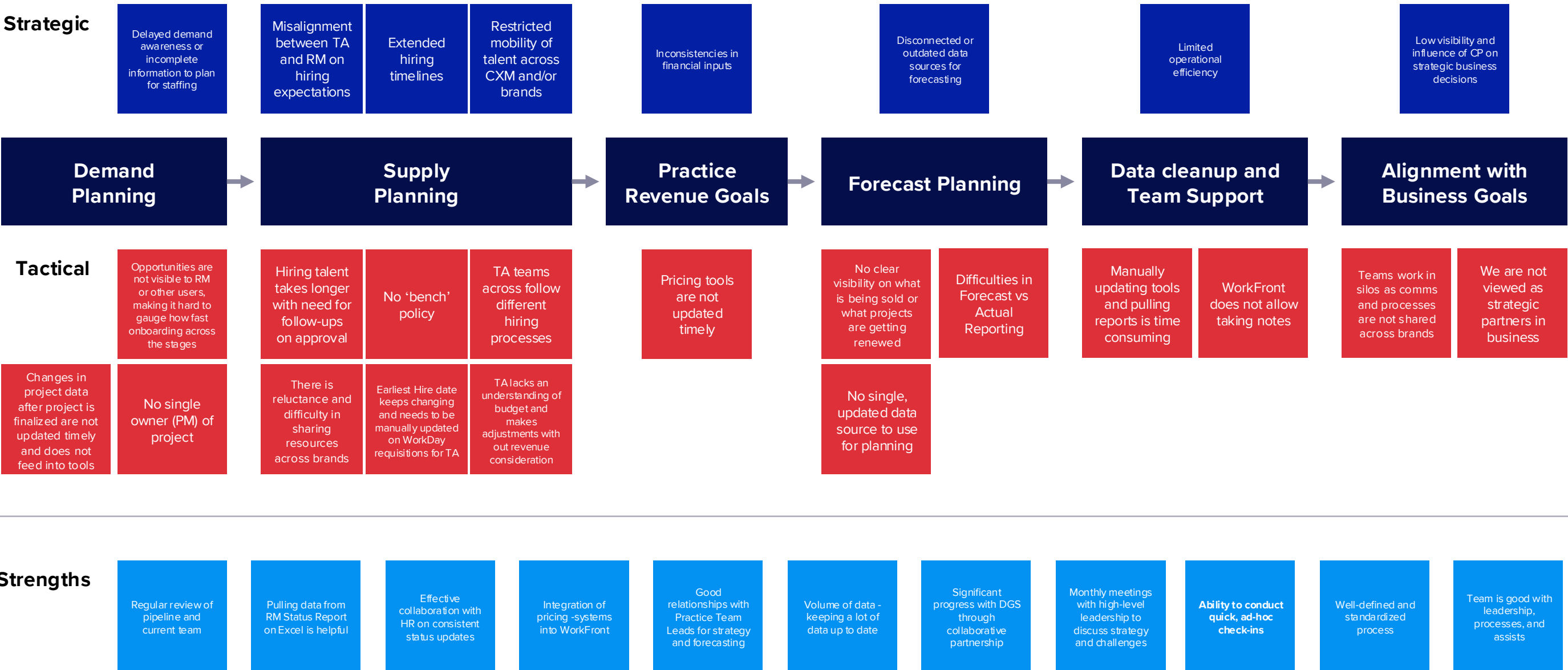
Mapped challenges to processes, identified and segregated constraints



Illustrative snapshots from the Miro board

SEGREGATING CHALLENGES

By mapping segregated challenges to the 6-step process, teams were able to move beyond tactical issues and concentrate on strategic levers that drive capacity outcomes





“Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Nulla nec leo nunc. Duis convallis ornare sem elementum iaculis. Curabitur luctus leo et ligula interdum posuere nec at enim.”

— Adam Organ, Head of Capacity Planning



EVOLVING INTO **STRATEGIC** CAPACITY PLANNING

The teams came together to envision a successful future, frame the correct problems and ideate strategic solutions by applying the Design Thinking approach.

TRANSITIONING FROM **RESOURCE MANAGEMENT** TO **CAPACITY PLANNING**

RESOURCE MANAGEMENT

- Functions at a micro level, focused on current projects, known needs, and assigned work
- Tactical and administrative today, managing short-term staffing
- Represents a point-in-time view within the capacity planning continuum

We shifted perspectives - from fragmented views of resource management to a shared, strategic understanding of capacity planning.

CAPACITY PLANNING

- Operates at a macro level, aligned to business goals and long-term demand
- Monitors trends and predicts future requirements using available inputs
- Focuses on building capabilities

WHAT IS CAPACITY PLANNING?

Capacity planning is a **strategic, future-looking, and predictive practice** that aligns market and client demand with the organization's talent, skills, and operating model.

What it does?

Consumes and **influences demand forecast** and **identifies capacity** or skill gaps

Guides hiring, upskilling, and resource deployment to ensures the organization is capacity-ready in line with future demand and what the business aims to sell

Builds relationships with key stakeholders, drives cost-to-serve goals, and enables scalable, sustainable growth

A SHARED VISION FOR FUTURE SUCCESS

Vision 2028

Capacity Planning **is a strategic, trusted partner** that drives Merkle's growth by enabling adaptive resource strategies, elevating client delivery and team satisfaction, and powering organizational transformation by bringing in profitability and a competitive advantage.

How the vision manifests

Our toolsets are now unified, with AI handling tactical work and allowing the team to **direct more time toward strategic, higher-value initiatives.**

Capacity Planning is now seen as a **strategic authority within our organization and across the industry**, positioned to compete alongside leading consulting firms.

Resource Management consulting is embedded within delivery, **directly contributing to project value creation and revenue impact.**

We act as **trusted partners and change agents**, continuously advocating for stakeholders and driving meaningful business transformation.

We have **championed internal mobility, building an agile, cross-functional talent pool** that operates seamlessly across CXM and the wider organizational network.

Capacity Planning is **empowered to influence organizational culture.**

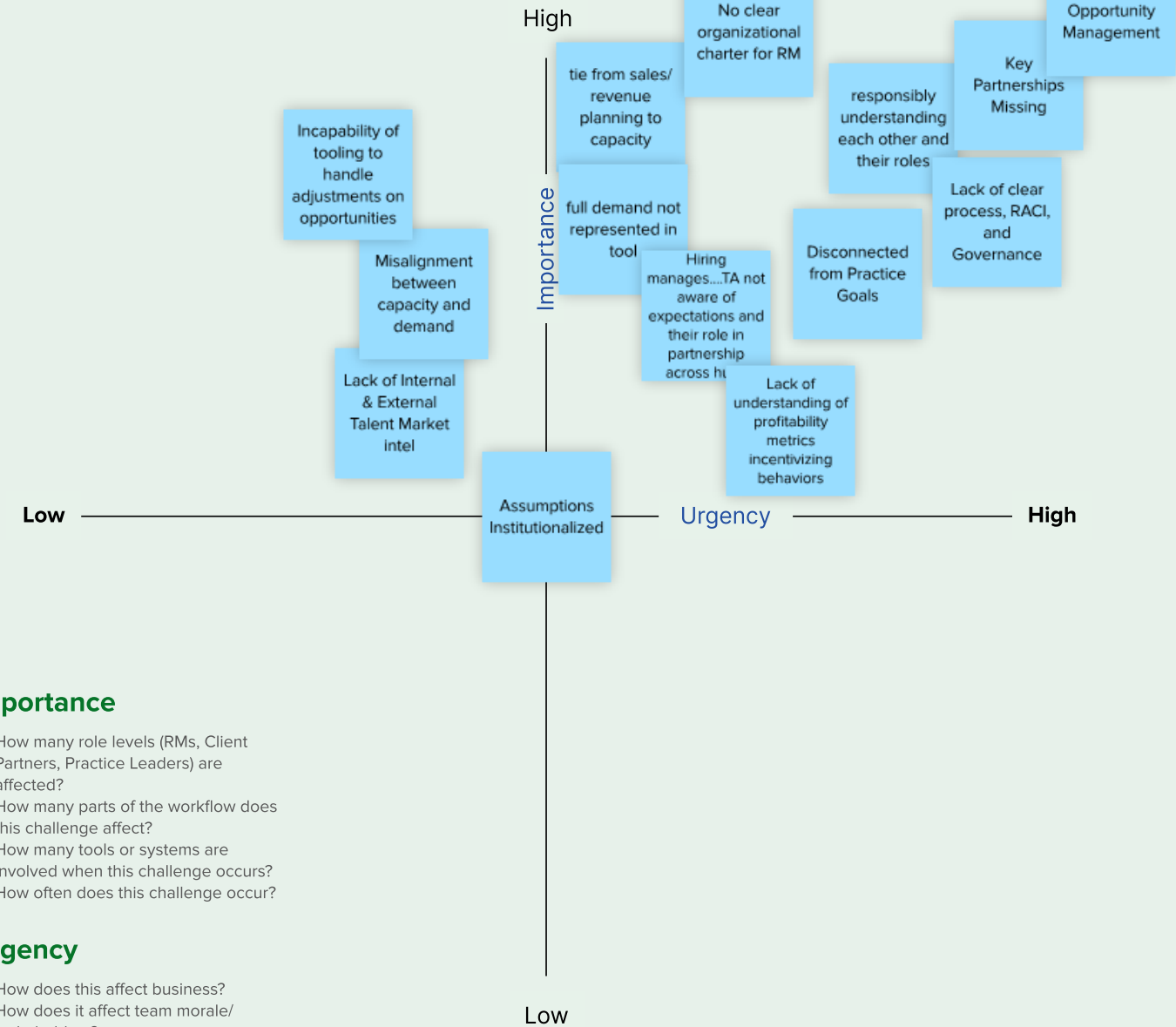
PROBLEM FRAMING

Uncovering root causes and prioritizing challenges helped to build sustainable, impactful and meaningful solutions.

PRIORITIZING CHALLENGES

With a strategic mindset, teams collaboratively prioritized challenges by impact and urgency to focus on the high-value challenges for solutioning.

CHALLENGE LANDSCAPE



Importance

- How many role levels (RMs, Client Partners, Practice Leaders) are affected?
- How many parts of the workflow does this challenge affect?
- How many tools or systems are involved when this challenge occurs?
- How often does this challenge occur?

Urgency

- How does this affect business?
- How does it affect team morale/ stakeholders?

Constraints

- Things beyond our control
- Things we have limited influence on

Can't force people to use and/or Lack of Standard Engagement Models

Lack of system and process integration (PSA)

Poor "Source Of Truth" Culture

Diffuse & inconsistent pricing approach

Inconsistent & Diffuse Delivery Management ("Methodology"?)

SWITCHING FROM PROBLEM TO SOLUTION MINDSET

Prioritized challenges were reframed as “How might we” statements that embraced complexity, paving the way for ideation.

“How might we **get TA Hub leads to align with the business to achieve capability goals and understanding** even though **this is not a part of their goals.**”

“How might we **help BI achieve summarization of account continuity across MSS2, add revenue to US&D, automate RM status reporting and model FTEs without PTs** even though detailed requirements are unclear or still evolving.”

“How might we **partner with
CRG, CXM Managers, PM's,
tools/platform owners** achieve
**faster project staffing,
understand their role in the
staffing process and maintain
data hygiene.**”

PROBLEM SOLVING

Ideating for solutions allowed the teams to explore new approaches, and envision future success with a design thinking lens

EXPLORING IDEAS FOR THE FUTURE

The "How-Might-We" statements set the tone for strategic ideation by leveraging key partners, and strengths, and envisioning success outcomes.

“How might we help BI achieve summarization of account continuity across MSS2, add revenue to US&D, automate RM status reporting and model FTEs without PTs even though detailed requirements are unclear or still evolving.”		What will success look like?
What strengths can we leverage here? Power BI capabilities Underlying data relationships	Idea Canvas Not digging for answers Which is the right PT? What renewals are of concern?	
Who can be our strategic partners? Ops dev Team Ops Leads Transformation Leads		

“How might we **partner with CRG, CXM Managers, PM's, tools/platform owners** achieve **faster project staffing, understand their role in the staffing process and maintain data hygiene.**”

What strengths can we leverage here?

Engagement models	Understanding of our tools	understanding how the business is run/overview
Asking the right questions to get a better cost to serve	RM relationships within the business	

Who can be our strategic partners?

Finance	PMO	HR
Sales/CRG Team	Account Management	PgMO

Idea Canvas

Modelling project teams options for growth teams	Engaging Sales/Account management / capability leads	data hygiene starts at the top. CP/Sales/growth
Becoming more account focused	Building relationships so they come to us to help model	scale RM to Sales/growth
Lead time reporting as an indicator of capacity	identifying all partnerships	
education to Growth teams around the impact when data isn't in systems and potential delays on confirming project teams		

What will success look like?

More pipeline conversations	engagement model and getting in early conversations before PT
strategic partner	CRG pulls RM in when talking to the client
able to staff Opp 30-60 days	less friction between RM's and sales teams
getting ahead of Opps to ahead of needs	RM in meeting in the beginning
Client happy about how we staffed opp and wants to bring more work to Merkle	

“How might we help **our finance team** achieve **increased effectiveness** in partnering with the **RM teams** and understand impact of their **mutual KPI's** even though **they have other priorities.**”

What will success look like?

Regular: cost to serve and margin review by account (RM/ FIN/Del-PM)

RM / Finance to plan to get resourcing back in line to ODE

What strengths can we leverage here?

Current touchpoints

Revenue review cycles

Labor cost review

Hiring

Margin review

Delivery governance

Idea Canvas

Come together as a team for staffing & margin (CTS) discussions by account

Get \$\$ and Hours in one system (add \$\$ to US&D)

education to Growth teams around the impact when data isn't in systems and potential delays on confirming project teams

Who can be our strategic partners?

Finance

Delivery (PM)

SOLUTION HYPOTHESES

Design Thinking requires continuous testing and refinement. A crucial next step was to validate the viability of the ideas generated.

FRAMING SOLUTION HYPOTHESES

To move ideas from concept to impact, we framed solution hypotheses to test what works, learn fast, and turn potential into progress.

Choose an idea		
Engaging Sales/Account management / capability leads		
What is the outcome we expect?	What assumptions are we making?	Why do we believe this will work?
closer partnership Growth,AM,HR,Finance leading to better alignment on Opp data and helping to drive revenue recognition	Ability to scale RM / growth teams and capability leads All teams will buy into increased engagement	There is a business need from finance (cost to serve), leadership and Sales to be better partners to support the profitability.
Hypotheses If we build trust and strong relationships with CLG/Account Management capability leads then, we're brought into discussions early can help drive CTS and data integrity improves as a result because RM needs a seat at the table to help drive business decisions. This will work only if we build strong partnerships and buy-in.		

Choose an idea

Come together as a team for staffing & margin (CTS) discussions by account

What is the outcome we expect?

- Build the FMO-RMO relationship
- Bring concerning outliers together (fin/RMO) to PMO/Account

What assumptions are we making?

- May be happening but not consistently
- Data/reporting will be easily accessible
- Further investigation may be required to find root causes

Why do we believe this will work?

- This is core focus to quickly add value to the business

Hypotheses

“If we **partner with the finance team to review and identify areas of margin and cost-to-serve**, then **we can help the business identify and address causes** because **these reviews are core focus area**. This will work **only if we obtain buy-in and commitment from FMO and PMO.**”

THE PATH FORWARD

Let's revisit how a few simple changes in everyday workflow, mindset, and habits can help to inculcate design thinking and open new horizons.

FROM EMBRACING THE MINDSET...

#1

EMPATHY
first

HOW

- Understand **who is affected** by the problem/situation
- Step **into others' shoes**, role-play & experience what happens

#2

Keep
CURIOSITY alive!

HOW

- Question the **"WHY"** and ask it often.
- Accept that there can be **multiple RIGHT answers**

#3

Accept
AMBIGUITY!

HOW

- **Be experimental** and open to fail often and learn fast
- **explore the messy ends** & avoid jumping to conclusions

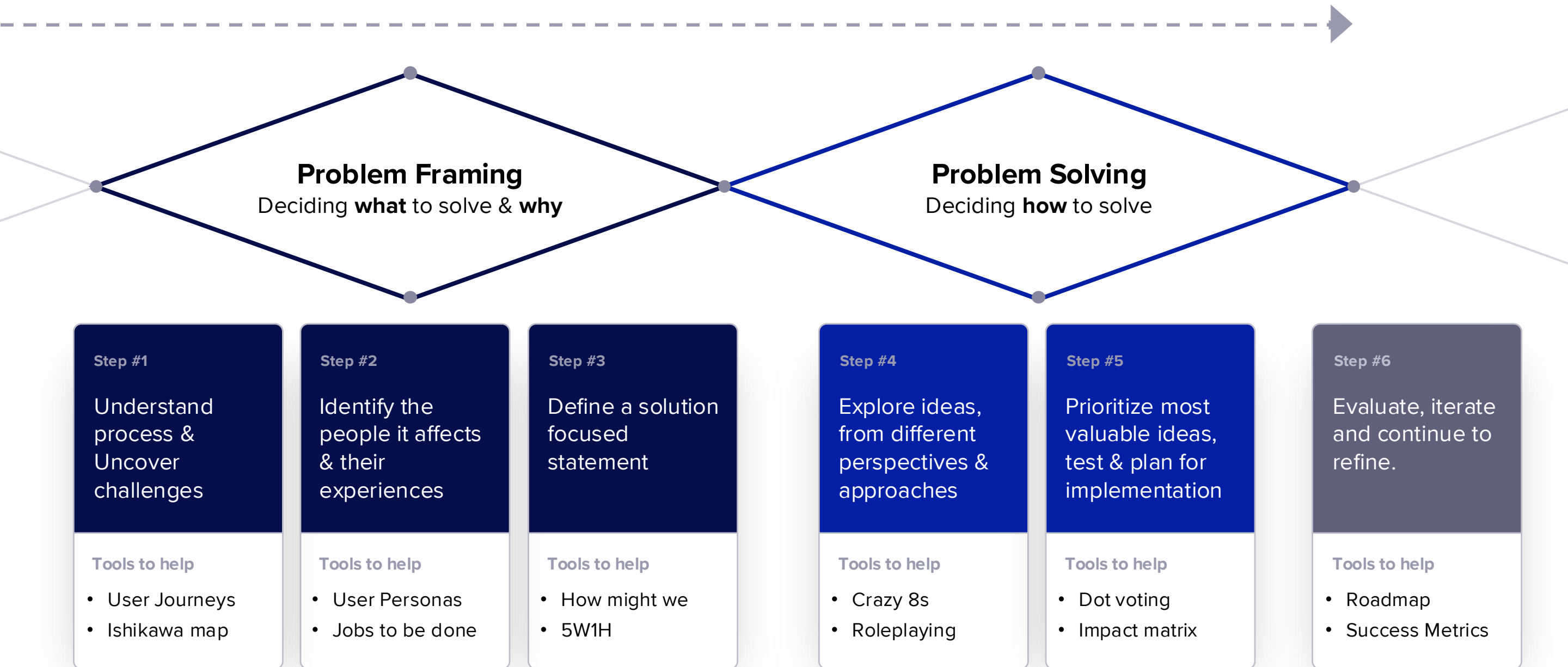
#4

Collaborate &
EXPLORE

HOW

- Adopt a **'yes, and/no but'** rule. There are no wrong ideas!
- Use co-creation sessions to bring together

... TO PUTTING IT IN PRACTICE



DESIGN THINKING FRAMEWORKS FOR CAPACITY PLANNING

Sample frameworks along with the 'ready-to-use' templates for capacity planning, to help teams adopt the design thinking approach

Prioritization Matrix

What is it

Prioritize multiple challenges/ideas by evaluating them based on Importance and Urgency to focus effort on what matters most

How to use

- List all identified challenges/ideas
- Capture non-actionable items under Constraints and low-insight topics in the Parking Lot
- Assess each challenge/ idea on Importance (impact, reach, frequency) and Urgency (business or people impact)
- Place challenges/ ideas on the matrix based on group consensus
- Focus on the items in the High importance and High urgency quadrant to define them further

Pro Tip

Best used after discovery to align teams on shared priorities before solutioning

Importance

- How many role levels are affected?
- How many parts of the workflow does this challenge affect?
- How many tools or systems are involved when this challenge occurs?
- How often does this challenge occur?

Urgency

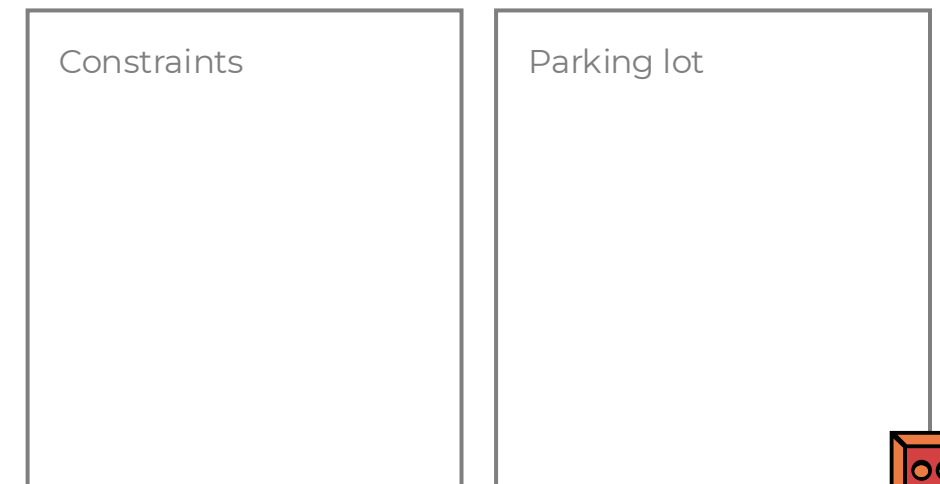
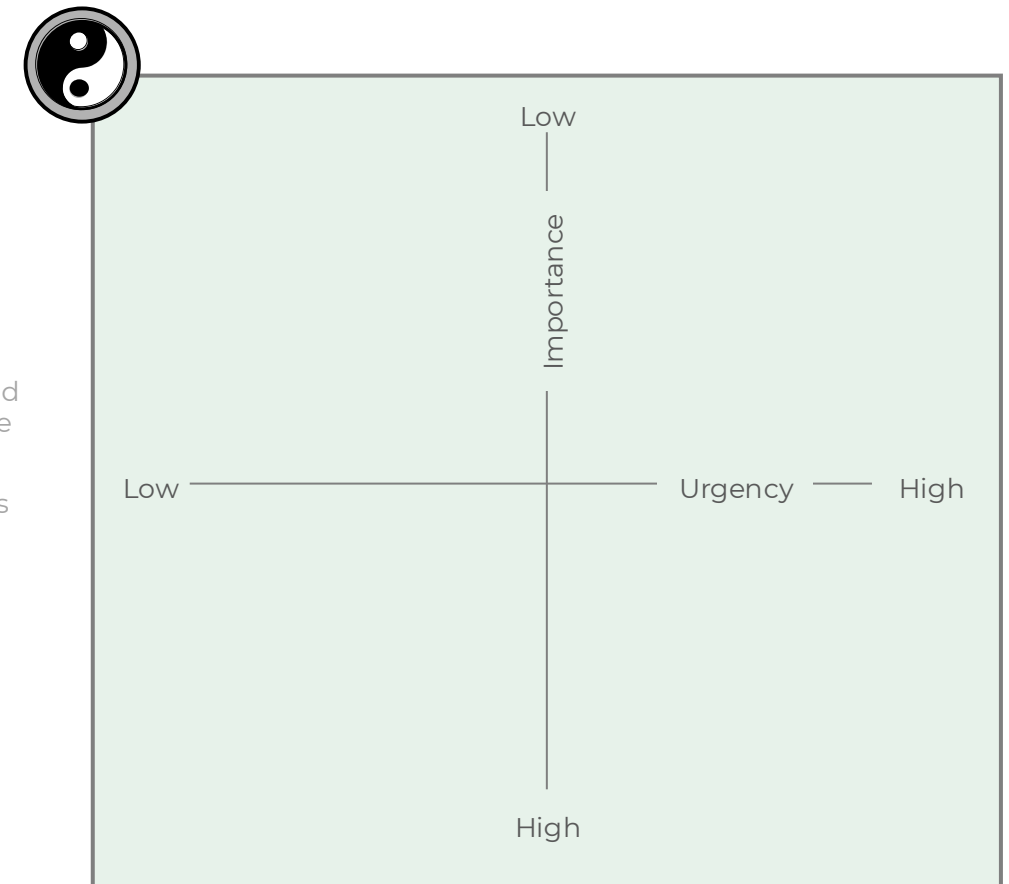
- How does this affect business?
- How does it affect team morale/ stakeholders?

Constraints

- Things beyond our control
- Things we have limited influence on

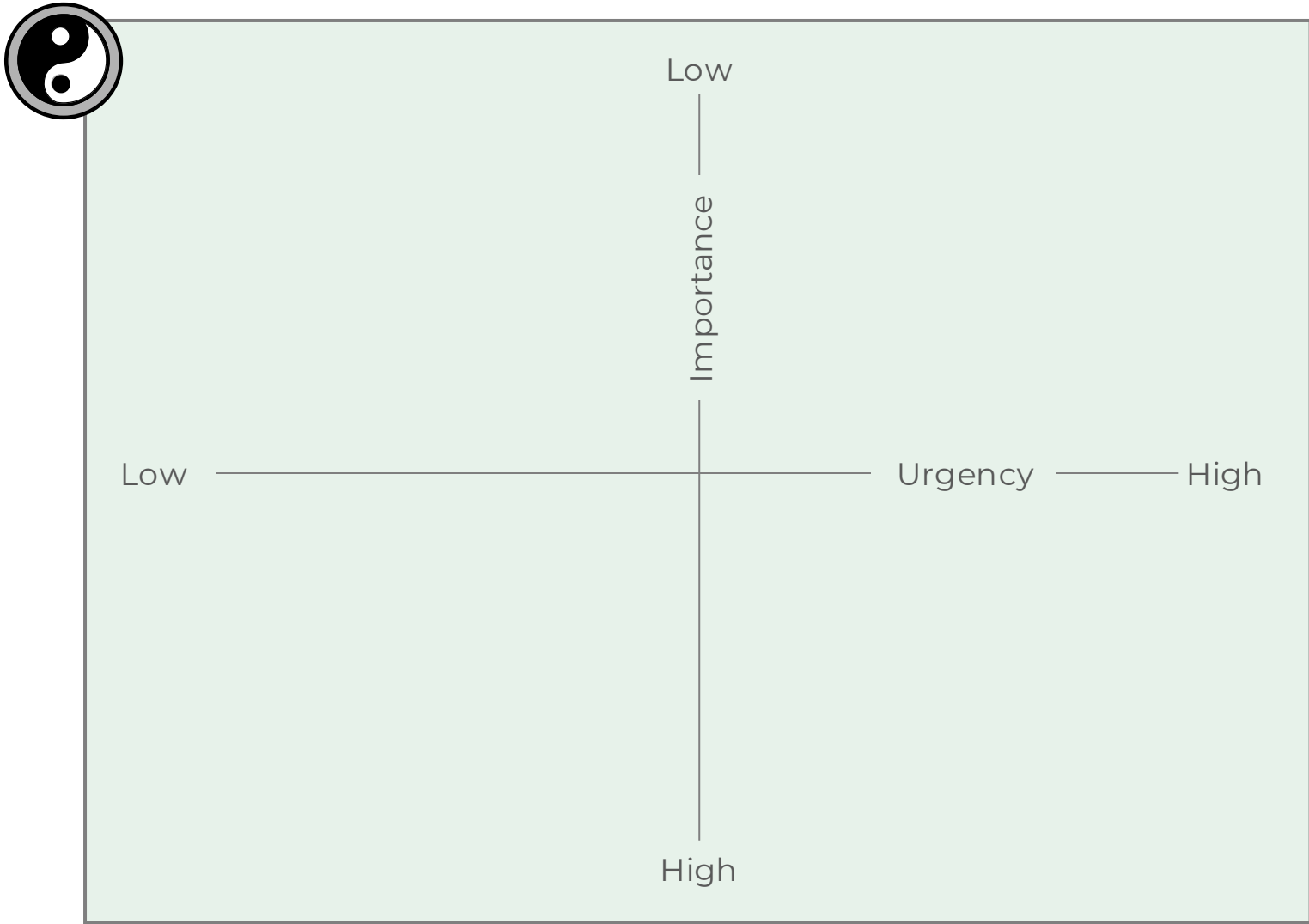
Parking Lot

- Things beyond our visibility



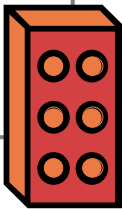
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Constraints

Parking lot



Importance

- How many role levels are affected?
- How many parts of the workflow does this challenge affect?
- How many tools or systems are involved when this challenge occurs?
- How often does this challenge occur?

Urgency

- How does this affect business?
- How does it affect team morale/stakeholders?

Constraints

- Things beyond our control
- Things we have limited influence on

Parking Lot

- Things beyond our visibility



How-Might-We

What is it

A reframing tool that converts challenges into clear, opportunity-led questions to spark focused and creative ideation

How to use

- Start with a clear challenge identified during the session
- Identify who the challenge affects and what outcome needs to improve
- Acknowledge the key constraint and things out of control
- Frame the statement as a How Might We question that invites multiple possible solutions
- Use the question as a shared prompt for focused ideation

Pro Tip

Use this tool when teams feel stuck in problem statements and need to shift from analysis to possibility-driven thinking

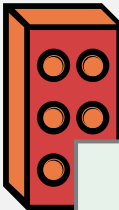
How might we (help/ support) _____ Who the challenge affects comes here _____ (user)

achieve _____ Identify desired outcomes here _____ (desired outcome)

even though _____ Acknowledge key constraint/ things out of control here _____ (existing tension/ constrains)

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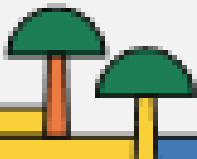
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How might we (help/ support) Type here.... (user)

achieve _____ (desired outcome)

even though _____ (existing tension/ constrains)



Idea Canvas

What is it

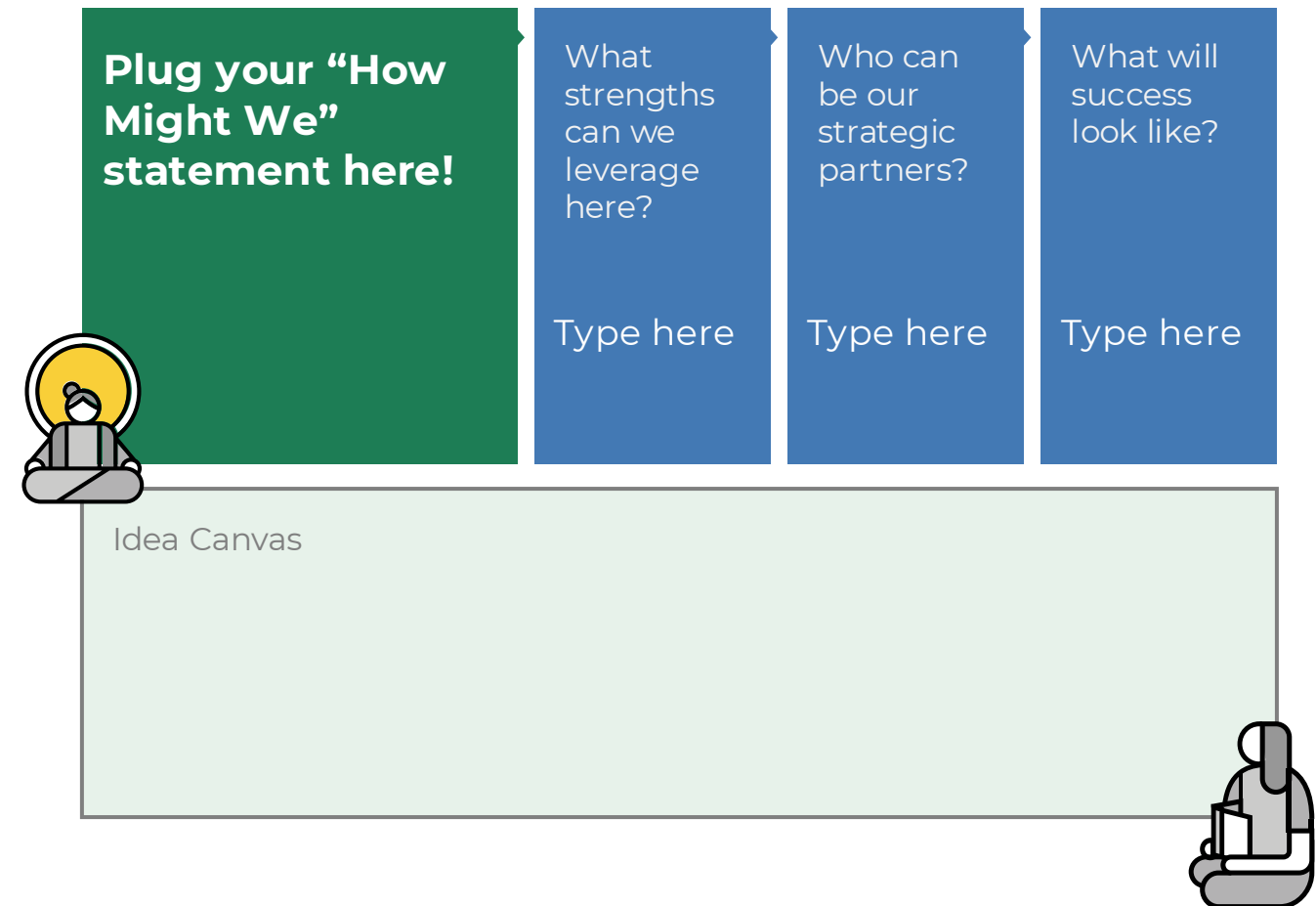
A framework that converts How Might We questions into actionable ideas grounded in real strengths and success criteria

How to use

- Plug your How Might We statement, defining the user, desired outcome, and constraint to the framework
- Explore existing strengths that can be leveraged to address the challenge
- Identify strategic partners or stakeholders who could enable or accelerate solutions
- Define what success looks like to create a shared direction for ideation
- Generate ideas in the Idea Canvas, using all inputs as inspiration rather than constraints
- Review and cluster ideas before moving into prioritization or validation

Pro Tip

Use this framework to move from open brainstorming to practical, outcome-focused ideas grounded in real capabilities



 Prepared by: Team/individual name goes here

 Date: Type here

Plug your “How Might We” statement here

What strengths can we leverage here?

Type here

Who can be our strategic partners?

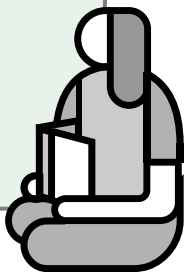
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What will success look like?

Type here



Idea Canvas



Idea Definition

What is it

A structured way to explore the viability of a chosen idea by examining its intent, logic, and real-world application

How to use

- Select a strong idea and align on what success should look like
- Discuss how the idea would work in practice and why it makes sense in the current context
- Identify key assumptions, risks, and dependencies that could affect success
- Frame a clear hypothesis to guide implementation, testing, or next steps

Pro Tip

Use this framework after selecting an idea to help teams build clarity, confidence, and feasibility before moving ahead

Chosen Idea

What is the outcome we expect?

Type here

What strengths can we leverage?

Type here

Why do we believe this will work?

Type here

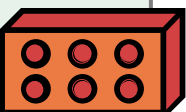


If we (Intervention/ idea) Type here

then (outcome)

because (rationale)

this will work only if (assumptions)



 Prepared by: Team/ individual name goes here

 Date: Type here

Chosen Idea

What is the outcome we expect?

Type here

What strengths can we leverage?

Type here

Why do we believe this will work?

Type here

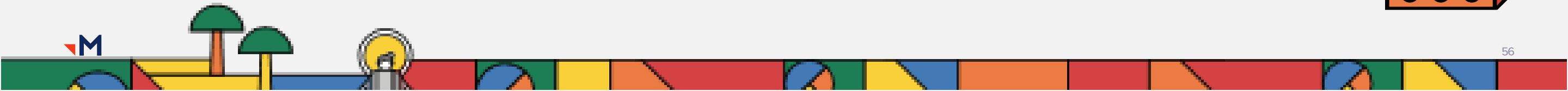
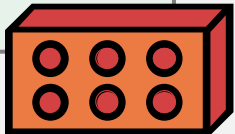


If we (Intervention/ idea) Type here

then (outcome) _____

because (rationale) _____

this will work only if (assumptions) _____



Roadmap

What is it

A planning framework that helps teams translate priorities into a phased plan, aligning goals, ownership, and success measures over time

How to use

- Create a list of all the ideas/ goals
- Break the goals/ ideas into quarter-wise focus areas or actions
- Identify who is responsible and what needs to be achieved in each phase
- Identify success indicators to track progress
Note key dependencies or risks that could impact delivery

Pro Tip

Use this framework after selecting an idea to help teams build clarity, confidence, and feasibility before moving ahead

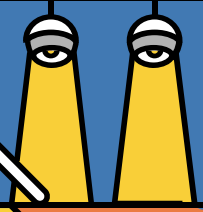
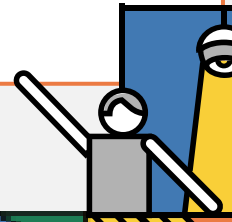
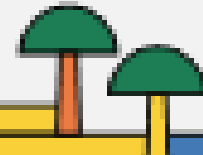
	Quarter 1	Quarter 2	Quarter 3	Quarter 4
Our Quarterly goals	Type here			
What are we doing to achieve it? & who does it?				
We know we're successful when...				
What are the dependencies we need to be careful about?				



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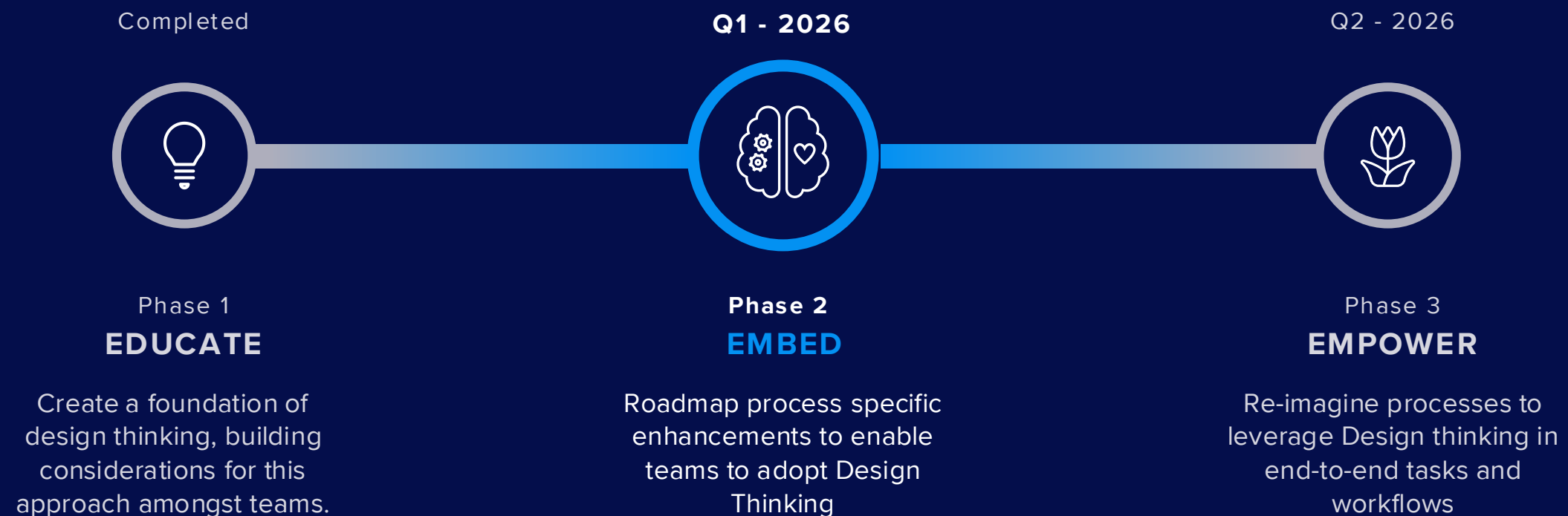
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	Quarter 1	Quarter 2	Quarter 3	Quarter 4
 Our Quarterly goals	Type here			
What are we doing to achieve it? & who does it?				
We know we're successful when...				
What are the dependencies we need to be careful about?				



HOW WE CAN CONTINUE TO ENGAGE

This marks the beginning of a shift - from capacity planning as an operational exercise to a strategic capability - enabled by Design Thinking.



REFLECTIONS FROM PARTICIPANTS

Your thoughts on the workshop experience



GLIMPSES FROM THE WORKSHOP

